The Black Death: what changed? (written)

Ember · two PEEL paragraphs · about 40 minutes Date: _____

Skill: So What? After every Evidence sentence, write one more sentence: what does this show people wanted, feared or believed? Point back at the evidence. Use the fact lists, in your own words.

Socioeconomic: work and community

- **S1** *(June 1348, Dorset)* The Black Death reached England at the port of Melcombe (Weymouth). By 1350 it had killed between a third and a half of the people in England.
- **S2** *(1348–50, everywhere)* With so many dead, there were not enough workers to plough, sow and harvest. Some crops were left to rot in the fields.
- **S3** *(1349 onwards)* Surviving peasants asked for higher wages. Some left their lord's manor to work for whoever paid most, even though villeins (unfree peasants) were not allowed to leave.
- **S4** *(1349 and 1351, laws)* The **Ordinance of Labourers** (1349) and the **Statute of Labourers** (1351) said wages must stay at the level they were before the plague. Workers who refused could be punished.
- **S5** *(after 1350)* Some lords who could not find workers switched from growing crops to keeping **sheep**, which needed far fewer workers. Others rented their land out for money instead of making peasants work it for free.
- **S6** *(over the next 100 years)* **Serfdom** (villeinage) slowly died out in England. More peasants paid rent in money and were free to move.
- **S7** *(England, 1350–1500)* Some villages shrank or were abandoned. Historians have found the remains of hundreds of **deserted villages**. The plague, later outbreaks and the switch to sheep all played a part.
- **S8** *(1363, law)* A law said what **clothes** each rank of people was allowed to wear, because some ordinary people now had more money and were dressing like the better-off.
- **S9** *(London, 1348–49)* So many people died that new burial grounds were opened, such as East Smithfield, where bodies were laid side by side in long trenches.

Cultural: beliefs and mindset

- **C1** *(1348–49, everywhere)* Most people believed the plague was sent by **God** as a punishment for sin. They responded with prayer, processions, pilgrimages and gifts to the Church.
- **C2** *(Paris, 1348)* Doctors at the University of Paris blamed the **planets**: they said Saturn, Jupiter and Mars had lined up in 1345 and poisoned the air.
- **C3** *(1348–49)* Many believed in **miasma**: disease spread through bad air and foul smells. People carried sweet-smelling herbs and flowers to protect themselves.
- **C4** *(Europe, 1348–49)* **Flagellants** went from town to town whipping themselves in public to show God they were sorry. They were mostly in Germany and the Low Countries; a group came to London in 1349, but the English did not join in. The Pope condemned them in 1349.
- **C5** *(Europe, 1348–49)* In parts of Europe, **Jews were blamed** for poisoning wells and thousands were killed, for example in Strasbourg in February 1349. This did not happen in England, because Jews had been expelled from England in 1290.
- **C6** *(England, 1348–50)* Priests visited the sick, so many caught the plague and died. Some were replaced by men with little training. Prayer had not stopped the plague, and some people began to lose respect for the **Church**.
- **C7** *(after 1350)* Other people became **more religious**. More rich people paid for chantries: priests whose job was to pray for their souls after they died.
- **C8** *(the century after)* Art became focused on **death**. The "Dance of Death" showed skeletons leading kings, bishops and peasants alike to the grave. Some rich people had tombs carved showing their body as a rotting corpse, like Archbishop Chichele's in Canterbury Cathedral (1420s).
- **C9** *(Florence, Italy, 1348)* The writer Boccaccio described how some people shut themselves away and lived very carefully, while others drank and partied because they might die tomorrow.

Three traps

- **Don't copy the fact.** Put it in your own words and keep the date or place.
- **No hindsight.** They did not know about germs, rats or fleas (that came over 500 years later). Ask why *they* thought something would help.
- **Political changes are not in your task** (for example the Peasants' Revolt, 1381). Leave them out.

Plan (5 min): fact numbers and a few words, not sentences

	Socioeconomic	**Cultural**
P Point		
E1 fact no.		
So what?		
E2 fact no.		
So what?		
L Link		

Paragraph 1. How did the Black Death change life for working people and communities? (socioeconomic)

Paragraph 2. How did the Black Death change what people believed and thought? (cultural)

Self-check (5 min)

□ Each paragraph has two pieces of evidence, each with a date, place, law or number.

□ Every piece of evidence has a So What straight after it.

□ Every So What points back at its evidence and says what people wanted, feared or believed.

□ The facts are in my own words.

□ No hindsight and nothing political.